(UNCLOS), which was agreed to in 1982 and came into force in 1994. UNCLOS demarcates twelve nautical miles from a country's coast as territorial waters, a further contiguous zone for hot pursuit, an exclusive economic zone (EEZ) extending up to 200 nautical miles from the coast for exploiting natural resources, and international waters beyond that. In practice, these principles are fundamental to the development of maritime economies, coastal security, and freedom of commercial and military navigation. There are even dispute resolution mechanisms, such as the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea (ITLOS) in Hamburg. Although the United States has still not ratified the agreement, China's territorial claims in the South China Sea and its refusal in 2016 to accept international arbitration in a dispute with the Philippines have further eroded the principles of UNCLOS.

Other mechanisms to govern the global commons include the Outer Space Treaty of 1967, which bans weapons of mass destruction and assigns responsibilities for objects launched into space. But China's 2007 anti-satellite test, which created considerable debris, and unsuccessful attempts at creating more ambitious codes of conduct of space mean that the risks to safety, management of space debris, and weaponization of outer space remain priorities. The Antarctic Treaty System, where India has consultative status, preserves that continent for scientific research and bans military activity. However, there are concerns that the limitations imposed by these arrangements are being tested by some countries, including China. The Arctic has been less well governed and has seen greater competition between the eight Arctic states for resources and territory. In 2013, India joined the Arctic Council—the primary international forum to discuss Arctic issues—as an observer. [4]

The atmosphere and climate long proved a contentious area to reach international agreement because of the potential costs to industrialization and economic development. In the 1980s and 1990s, concerns increased that human activity resulting in the emissions of carbon dioxide and other gases would cause average atmospheric temperatures to rise more than 2°, temperatures never experienced in human history. While acknowledging the